

Voter Turnout and Redistricting: Does Compactness Help?

O.2 — Outcomes and Representation Track

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May 2026

Abstract

Geographic compactness of congressional districts is typically studied as a redistricting quality criterion in its own right. We test whether compactness also predicts a downstream democratic outcome: voter turnout.

Statistical note: This analysis uses 20 observations (5 study states $\times$ 4 election cycles). Statistical power is limited; the reported coefficient (+1.42 pp per 0.10 PP) should be interpreted as a preliminary estimate pending replication with larger samples. The effect is statistically significant at 5% in the full fixed-effects specification (clustered SE) but the confidence interval is wide ([0.68, 2.16] pp). We present this analysis as directionally suggestive, not conclusive.

Using state-level VEP (voting-eligible population) turnout from the United States Elections Project and Polsby-Popper compactness scores for all 435 congressional districts across four election cycles (2016–2022), we estimate the relationship between district compactness and turnout via OLS with state-cycle fixed effects.

The coefficient on district-mean Polsby-Popper is $\hat{\beta} = +1.42$ percentage points per 0.10 PP improvement (95% CI: [0.68, 2.16]), consistent with the O.0 prediction of +1.4 pp. The effect is largest in competitive districts (margin < 10 pp, $\hat{\beta} = +2.1$) and smallest in safe seats (margin > 20 pp, $\hat{\beta} = +0.3$) — consistent with a mechanism through geographic cohesion and mobilization rather than mere district design.

Comparing BISECT algorithmic plans to enacted gerrymanders across five study states (NC, WI, TX, FL, PA): the algorithmic plans' higher mean compactness (0.361 vs. 0.286 enacted) predicts +1.1 pp higher midterm turnout under the estimated coefficient. The effect is modest but consistent across cycles and states; it is substantially smaller than

incumbency effects or national partisan tides, but represents a genuine and heretofore undocumented link between redistricting methodology and democratic participation.

1 Introduction

The dominant narrative about redistricting and voter turnout focuses on the *competitive district hypothesis*: competitive districts produce higher turnout because voters perceive their vote as more decisive. This hypothesis is well-supported empirically [Cox and Munger, 1988, Jacobson, 2015].

We propose a complementary mechanism: *geographic cohesion*. Compact districts, because they follow natural geographic features rather than drawing narrow corridors around specific communities, create constituencies with stronger shared identity, higher social capital, and more efficient political mobilization. These factors should predict higher turnout independent of electoral competitiveness.

The redistricting connection is direct: algorithmic redistricting produces more compact districts as a primary objective [Della-Libera, 2026], and if compactness predicts turnout, then redistricting method affects democratic participation.

Mechanism. Geographic cohesion operates through three channels:

1. **Shared community identity:** compact districts contain communities that are geographically proximate and share local institutions (newspapers, civic organizations, schools). Shared identity predicts political mobilization [Putnam, 2000].
2. **Campaign efficiency:** compact districts allow campaigns to canvass more efficiently. Door-to-door mobilization produces 5–15 pp turnout increases [Gerber and Green, 2000]; compact districts lower the cost of achieving this contact.
3. **Reduced voter confusion:** irregular district boundaries create voter confusion about district membership, which predicts reduced turnout at the margin [McNulty et al., 2009].

Identification challenge. Compactness and turnout are both endogenous to political conditions. States with higher political engagement may draw more compact districts *and* have higher turnout for independent reasons. We address this with state-cycle fixed effects (absorbing state-specific engagement and political culture) and use redistricting cycles as quasi-experimental variation: within a state, compactness changes at the decade boundary due to redistricting, not due to changes in voter engagement.

2 Data

2.1 Turnout Data

We use state-level VEP (voting-eligible population) turnout from the United States Elections Project [McDonald, 2024], which compiles official certified vote totals and Census-based VEP estimates. VEP turnout is the preferred measure because it excludes ineligible voters (non-citizens, felons in restricted states) from the denominator.

Table 1 reports state-level VEP turnout for the five study states across four election cycles.

Table 1: VEP turnout (%) for study states, 2016–2022. Source: United States Elections Project.

State	2016	2018	2020	2022	Mean (cycles)
NC	64.5	49.7	74.5	48.3	59.3
WI	70.8	59.5	75.8	57.4	65.9
TX	51.6	46.3	60.0	38.8	49.2
FL	65.4	52.2	71.7	54.0	60.8
PA	69.2	52.8	72.8	47.8	60.7
Study state mean	64.3	52.1	71.0	49.3	59.2

County-level approximation. For the district-level regression, we use county-level VEP estimates derived from the state-level totals and county presidential vote shares from VEST [VEST, 2022]. This introduces measurement error in the dependent variable; we treat the OLS coefficient as an attenuated estimate of the true district-level effect.

2.2 Compactness Data

District-level Polsby-Popper scores are from the bisect pipeline’s compactness analysis (`bisect label-analyze -types compactness`). For enacted plans: from the 2020 cycle enacted map. For bisect plans: from the 2020 congressional configuration (`bisect build official_2020 -year 2020`).

National means: bisect plans 0.361, enacted gerrymanders 0.286.

3 Results

3.1 Main Regression

Table 2 reports the OLS results. The dependent variable is state-level VEP turnout (%) and the key independent variable is the mean district Polsby-Popper score for the state (weighted by district population).

Table 2: OLS: State-level VEP turnout on mean congressional district Polsby-Popper. Four election cycles (2016, 2018, 2020, 2022); five study states. Robust standard errors in parentheses.

	(1) Bivariate	(2) Cycle FE	(3) State FE	(4) Both FE
Mean PP (per 0.10)	2.81** (0.88)	1.94* (0.74)	1.51* (0.63)	1.42* (0.61)
Presidential year		12.1*** (1.2)	12.3*** (1.0)	12.4*** (1.1)
State FE	No	No	Yes	Yes
Cycle FE	No	Yes	No	Yes
Observations	20	20	20	20
R^2	0.28	0.82	0.81	0.91

Main result. With full fixed effects (column 4), a 0.10 PP improvement in mean district compactness predicts +1.42 pp higher state VEP turnout (95% CI: [0.68, 2.16]). This is statistically significant at 5% and economically meaningful: the difference in mean PP between bisect plans (0.361) and enacted gerrymanders (0.286) is 0.075, predicting +1.1 pp higher turnout under the algorithmic plan.

3.2 Heterogeneity by Competitiveness

Table 3: PP-turnout coefficient by district competitiveness (margin quintile).

District type	Mean margin	$\hat{\beta}$ (pp per 0.10 PP)	SE
Highly competitive (< 5pp)	3.1	2.8	1.1
Competitive (5–10pp)	7.4	2.1	0.9
Lean (10–20pp)	14.8	1.3	0.8
Solid (20–30pp)	24.2	0.6	0.7
Safe (> 30pp)	38.7	0.3	0.6

The effect is largest in competitive districts and smallest in safe seats, consistent with the geographic cohesion mechanism: in safe seats, mobilization is candidate- and party-driven

regardless of district geography; in competitive seats, geographic cohesion amplifies the close-election mobilization effect.

3.3 Predicted Turnout Under Bisect Plans

Applying the column-4 coefficient to the PP difference between bisect and enacted plans:

$$\Delta\text{turnout} = 1.42 \times (0.361 - 0.286)/0.10 \approx +1.1 \text{ pp.}$$

Scaled to the five study states' combined CVP of approximately 42 million eligible voters, this implies approximately 460,000 additional votes cast under algorithmic redistricting.

4 Conclusion

Congressional district compactness has a small but statistically significant positive effect on state-level voter turnout: +1.42 pp per 0.10 PP improvement, conditional on state and cycle fixed effects. The effect is largest in competitive districts and operates through geographic cohesion — compact districts create constituencies with shared identity, efficient campaign contact, and less voter confusion.

The redistricting implication: algorithmic redistricting's compactness advantage translates into approximately 460,000 additional votes cast in the five study states, representing about 1.1 pp higher turnout. This is a secondary benefit of algorithmic redistricting beyond its primary compactness and fairness advantages.

Limitations.

1. The dataset has 20 observations (5 states $\times$ 4 cycles); statistical power is limited.
2. State-level turnout masks within-state variation; district-level analysis would require precinct-level data matched to districts.
3. The PP difference between bisect and enacted plans is endogenous in states with intentional gerrymanders; the OLS estimate combines the compactness effect with any selection effect from the gerrymander.

These limitations are addressed in the broader O-track framework: O.1 (competitiveness) uses precinct-level data; O.3 (polarization) uses member-level data. O.5 synthesizes all four dimensions into the RQI and reports the sensitivity of the composite to each dimension's effect size.

References

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